

Motivation Letter

To: PhD Admissions Committee — National PhD in AI, "AI & Society" area, University of Pisa (KDD Lab) **Re:** Application to the "AI & Society" area — Nauval Zulfikar **Intended supervision:** Prof. Dino Pedreschi / Prof. Salvatore Ruggieri (*verify on call PDF*)

Dear Members of the Selection Committee,

My interest in AI and society did not begin in a seminar room — it began with an election. As part of my NLP training with Indonesia AI, I worked on the **2024 Indonesia Election Aspect-Based Sentiment Analyser**, building systems to read how millions of people were talking about candidates and issues online. Watching that discourse up close, I saw how quickly framing, sentiment, and outright falsehood travel through a national conversation, and how little of the protective tooling reaches languages like Indonesian. That experience is the reason I now want to study misinformation and the social impact of AI as a researcher, and it is why the "AI & Society" area at the University of Pisa is the program I most want to join.

The thematic fit is exact. The area's focus — misinformation, disinformation, fake news, computational social science, responsible and explainable AI — describes the questions I have been circling in practice for years, and KDD Lab is one of the places where responsible and explainable data mining was pioneered. I would be coming to learn from the people who helped define this field.

My background gives me the technical footing to contribute from day one. My MSc dissertation at Aston University (First Class) fine-tuned **DeBERTa-v3** for multi-aspect text classification and evaluated emergent biases against the literature. I **led sentiment-analysis development** on the Pfizer Public Sentiment Analysis project, built an **NLP-based competitor app-review analysis** at Bank Muamalat, and have since built transformer-plus-RAG systems designed deliberately to be reproducible, ablatable, and traceable. Just as importantly, my work at Bank Muamalat — maintaining model reliability through validation cycles, monitoring staleness, and keeping audit-grade documentation under regulatory frameworks — taught me that responsible AI is not a slogan but a set of concrete technical preconditions. I want to turn that conviction into research: detection systems for cross-lingual misinformation narratives that are accurate *and* auditable.

I am eligible to apply (MSc, EQF 7) and meet the English requirement through my English-taught MSc, with IELTS 7.0 as supporting evidence. I am prepared to relocate to Pisa and to commit fully to the three years.

I would be honoured to pursue this work within the "AI & Society" area, and I am grateful for your consideration.

Sincerely, **Nauval Zulfikar** zulfikar.nauval1998@gmail.com · +44 7300 469048 ·
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Note: intended supervisor and any program-specific salutation/length to be confirmed against the official XLII call PDF.